

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 361

By McKenzie

A RESOLUTION to honor and congratulate Mary Elizabeth Goins on the celebration of her 104th birthday.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly pay tribute to those citizens who are celebrating special occasions in their estimable lives; and

WHEREAS, Mary Elizabeth Goins celebrated her 104th birthday on February 12, 2025, a milestone commemorated as yet another precious souvenir of life's rich pageant; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Goins has lived an amazing life and has experienced firsthand the breadth and span of American history; and

WHEREAS, born in New Market to George Franklin Staffney, Sr., and Lillian Henderson Staffney, Mrs. Goins is one of four children; she had three siblings: George Staffney, Julia Roper, and Dorothy Staffney; and

WHEREAS, Mary Goins attended Cottage Hill Elementary School and then graduated from Nelson Merry High School, where she played guard on the school's basketball team and sang in the choir; and

WHEREAS, her participation in high school sports was a manifestation of an inner passion, and throughout her life, she kept up with baseball, basketball, and football, amassing a profound depth of knowledge in each; and

WHEREAS, she cultivated a tender affection for the art of gardening, a love that her father first instilled in her through their family garden in New Market, and while she was still able, she maintained a vegetable garden and flowerbed that witnessed countless captivating blooms over the years; and

WHEREAS, after graduating from high school in 1940, she moved to Knoxville, where she found work at Miller's Department Store, and forty years later, she retired from Sears,

Roebuck, and Company, having been always beloved by her coworkers for her attention to detail and solicitude for her customers; during her work career and in her retirement, Mrs. Goins also served as an Avon representative; and

WHEREAS, she was married to her beloved husband, Thomas Lace Goins, for sixty-four years, a union blessed with three children, and she now enjoys a wealth of grandchildren and great-grandchildren; and

WHEREAS, a woman of deep and abiding faith, Mrs. Goins is an eighty-year member of Clinton Chapel AME Zion Church, where she is currently the oldest member of the congregation; in addition to the daily bread of her religious television programming, she has furthered her already intimate relationship with the Lord through generous service to Clinton Chapel, including serving as Director of Christian Education, a Sunday School teacher, and president of the Helen Spurgeon Circle Missionary Society; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Goins enjoyed playing bridge with the Saturday Night Cotillion Bridge Club, and she was also a consistent community servant, whether through helping with early voting or raising funds for service projects like the Heart Fund; her other interests include watching her favorite game shows and listening to religious music and audio books; and

WHEREAS, a joy to be around and a blessing to all who have the good fortune of knowing her, Mrs. Goins attributes her longevity to reading and studying the Bible, attending Sunday School and church, and following the principles outlined in Matthew 7:12 and James 1:5-6; and

WHEREAS, as Mary Goins continues in her 104th year, she remains a beloved member of her community who is admired for her wisdom, spirit of generosity, integrity, and enthusiasm for life; and

WHEREAS, we wish to grasp this golden opportunity to specially recognize one of Tennessee's most outstanding citizens on this very special occasion; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we hereby honor and congratulate Mary Elizabeth Goins on the celebration of her 104th birthday and extend to her our best wishes for many happy returns of the day.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.